



Lesson Notes

Fundamentals of Human Resource Management (HRM1)

Module 2: HRM's Organisational Role

Lesson 2: Specialties in HRM

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HRIS and Technology Specialists

As organisations grow, HR work becomes too complex for generalists alone. This is where HR specialties emerge, professionals who focus deeply on one area of HR rather than covering all of it.

The first specialty is HR Information Systems and technology. These specialists implement and manage the software systems that run HR operations, including applicant tracking systems, payroll software, and employee databases. Globally, systems like Workday, Oracle HCM Cloud, and SAP SuccessFactors dominate large corporations (Bratton et al., 2021).

In Uganda, most organisations do not yet use these large international systems due to cost. Many rely on simpler tools such as payroll modules or in house spreadsheets managed by HR officers. Larger employers such as banks and telecoms are more likely to invest in dedicated HRIS platforms, since their staff numbers make manual systems impractical.

The value of HRIS specialists is efficiency. A well run system reduces errors in payroll, speeds up recruitment tracking, and gives management real time data on staffing, rather than waiting weeks for a manual report to be compiled.

Compliance and Risk Management in HRM, Uganda Context

Compliance and risk management specialists ensure the organisation follows all relevant labour laws, regulations, and internal policies. Getting this wrong exposes the organisation to legal disputes, fines, and reputational damage.

In Uganda, key statutes every HR compliance specialist must know include the Employment Act, Cap. 226, which governs contracts of employment, termination procedures, notice periods, leave entitlements, and protection against unfair dismissal (Republic of Uganda, 2024). The Occupational Safety and Health Act, Cap. 231, sets standards for workplace safety and requires reporting of workplace accidents. The Workers Compensation Act, Cap. 233, requires employers to compensate employees who suffer injury or illness arising from their work. The Labour Disputes (Arbitration and Settlement) Act, Cap. 227, sets out the process for resolving disputes between employers and employees through mediation and arbitration before matters escalate to court. The National Social Security Fund Act, Cap. 230, governs mandatory retirement savings contributions for employees in the private sector.

A compliance specialist's daily work includes conducting internal audits to check the organisation follows these laws, running compliance training for managers, and handling employee relations issues before they escalate into formal disputes or litigation (Armstrong, 2006).

A manufacturing plant in the Namanve Industrial Park that fails to register workers with NSSF, or ignores safety standards under the Occupational Safety and Health Act, risks not only fines but also losing workers' trust, which affects retention and productivity long term.

Reflect: *Why might smaller Ugandan businesses struggle more than large corporations to stay compliant with these laws, and what risks does that create for their employees?*

DEI, Workforce Analytics, and Learning and Development Specialists

Diversity, equity and inclusion specialists focus on fostering an inclusive workplace culture across gender, ethnicity, religion, and other differences. In Uganda, this often means navigating diversity across the country's many ethnic and regional identities within a single workplace, alongside improving gender representation in leadership roles.

Workforce planning and analytics specialists analyse HR data to guide business decisions, tracking turnover rates, time to hire, and training costs, then translating that data into recommendations for leadership. An HR analytics specialist who discovers unusually high turnover at one branch of a bank would investigate management practices at that specific location rather than assume the problem applies company wide.

Learning and development specialists design and deliver training programmes to build employee skills. In Uganda, this often blends formal classroom training with mentorship, since many organisations cannot afford expensive external training providers and instead build internal capacity through experienced staff mentoring newer employees (Dessler, 2016).

Diversity ensures the workforce reflects and respects Uganda's diversity, analytics gives HR evidence to act on rather than guesswork, and learning and development ensures the workforce keeps growing in capability. Together, these three move HR from simply managing people to actively strengthening the organisation's human capital.

Reflect: *If you were an HR analytics specialist and discovered one department had far higher turnover than others, what would you investigate first before concluding why?*

The Remaining HR Specialties

The remaining HR specialties round out the full picture of how large organisations divide HR work. HR business partnering aligns HR initiatives directly with business objectives, working closely with senior leadership. HR project management oversees HR related projects such as system implementations, ensuring these initiatives are completed on time and within budget. Organisational development and change management specialists drive transformation initiatives when organisations restructure, merge, or adopt new strategies.

Employee and labour relations specialists manage interactions between employees and management, including handling conflicts and, where unions exist, negotiating with them directly. Compensation and benefits specialists design pay structures and benefits packages, ensuring these remain competitive enough to attract and retain talent without straining the organisation's budget. Talent management and development specialists focus specifically on employee growth, retention, and long term career pathing within the organisation. Recruitment and talent acquisition specialists focus purely on attracting, selecting, and hiring new talent, often the most visible HR specialty to people outside the organisation.

Closing thought for this lesson: no single HR professional can be an expert in all of these areas at once. As organisations grow, specialisation becomes necessary, and understanding these specialties helps identify where a person's own strengths and interests within HR might eventually lie.